Liam L. Larmark



Radisa Nigge

Rapist Nigger



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CHAPTER 1

The day a rapist was born

On the streets of Puerto Madero roamed a young man who appeared to be a bit impaired. Stumbling across the streets, onlookers could only assume that he was going home. Some time ago, he had tried to drink his problems away, but before that, he had spent hours planning what he would say to his crush, only to get crushed by her rejection.

"Next year will be different; next year I won't be alone," he stuttered.

But life had other plans for him; it was only a matter of minutes before New Year's Eve became New Year's Day.

"Help!" screamed a young woman. He wandered in the direction of the voice, assuming it was merely a lover's quarrel, but nothing could prepare him for the truth. Before his eyes stood a seven-foot-tall dark figure. He couldn't make out what it was doing, but he heard a strange noise and in his mind, he knew what was going on.

"Stop it!" he shouted.

"What are you doing here, boy?" it replied.

Struggling to regain his composure, he shouted, "I—I said stop it!"

"What is your name, boy?" it said, ignoring his demand.

"Riderz," he muttered.

It stopped what it was doing and dashed towards him. The stranger he had saved could only run to safety. What else could she do? Riderz could not run; his body was paralyzed. He could not scream; his mouth was forcefully covered. All he could do was think. The dark stranger’s tongue twisted inhumanly into his ears, and he could feel it sucking on his brain and soul. It went on for what felt like hours, while the sky was painted in beautiful, loud colors signifying the end of a year.

The next day, he woke up naked on the same bridge, remembering only what had happened to him that night. Ever since that day, he would paint his body black and his lips red, reenacting what had occurred, thus the world came to know him as rapistnigger.

CHAPTER 2

Geo the last hero

Within the police precinct of Puerto Madero, George Gagnon was battling a case which fellow officers had dismissed.
“Geo, go home. Do you really think tomorrow will be the end of the world?”
“No, I'm just finishing work. And don't call me that; I’ll go home soon.”
“Really? I pegged you as one of those crazy Y2K preppers.”
“Can you leave me alone?”
“You shouldn't damage your only good eye on that computer, Geo.”
The last time his wife was at the office, she had accidentally called him by his pet name, Geo. Ever since then, his coworkers used it to tease him. George was very strict; he’d always say, “Home is home, and work is work. I’d prefer to keep them separate.” His coworkers thought of him as a cold but hard-working guy who was promoted to a commissioner officer within two years, though others knew him as a compassionate person.
Geo started nodding off and finally fell asleep. He dreamt of his time back in Canada, how he met his wife, and how they moved to Argentina.
“Geo!” His coworker woke him up from a marvelous dream of the past, so starkly in comparison to his current awful life.
“Yeah, yeah, I’ll get home.”
He walked out to the parking lot, where his car failed him.
“Not again.”
He would have taken a cab back home, but he had lost his wallet earlier that day, so he had to walk. Even though he was physically fit, he lived five miles away. Halfway through his journey, he felt tired, so he stopped at a bench to rest.
"Help!" squealed the voice of a young woman, pulling his mind back to his wife.
“Was this how she felt when she was assaulted?” he thought.
Following the voice, he ran through the back streets of Puerto Madero, looking for the stranger's voice again, which led to a bridge. Before his eyes strode a seven-foot-tall dark, inhuman figure, its hands twisted around the lady's arm, which seemed to paralyze her. To him, it looked like a monster. He wanted to stop it, but his legs couldn't move. Geo tried to form the word "stop," but fear froze his voice. In the end, all he could do was watch. Seconds felt like days, and then a voice pierced through the silence.

"Stop it!" it shouted.
"What are you doing here, boy?" it whispered, though the sound cut sharply through the air.
"I—I said stop it!"
"What is your name, boy?"
Geo struggled to understand the boy's muttering, but before he could figure out what he said, the figure launched toward the boy, pinning him to the ground. The lady ran past Geo as though he wasn't even there. What felt like hours passed, and two thousand fireworks exploded into the night sky for the new year, which snapped Geo awake.
"I became a police officer to save lives."
He pulled out a 9×19mm Parabellum semi-automatic pistol and fired off a barrage of bullets. It sent the figure back to the bridge's railings. He fired off more rounds, emptying his pistol into the figure until it capsized into the water. He walked over to check on the boy.
"This kid looks like he's just turned 20. Where are his clothes? I can't get him back to the station like this."
"Do you think you're a hero? This boy thought the same thing, look at him now."
The figure appeared behind Geo, gripping his neck with one hand, which paralyzed his body. He felt a strange, soft, wet object slithering its way into his ears and a hard object pressed against his backside. Before the figure could act out its sick wishes, it vanished.
"It came from here."
A group of teens appeared, one carrying a 35mm disposable camera and recording as he walked. Geo quickly ran to shield them from the gruesome scene before him. They bombarded him with questions; although his head was pounding, he tried to move them away from the kid's naked body while answering.
Thinking on his feet, he lied, "Someone tried to rob me. It was only self-defense."
"Is the gun legal?"
"Yes, I am a police officer."
"Why did you shoot him so much?"
"I was only trying to scare him off, but he was persistent."
"How could he rob an officer in Puerto Madero of all places? Is he stupid?"
"Do I look like an officer?"
"Why did you let him get away?"
"Well..."
"What did he look like?"
They were obviously intoxicated, so Geo walked with them to the nearest crowd, and then they parted ways. Away from the crowd, Geo's mind wandered back to the shadow figure.
"Even though I emptied my gun into him, he's still alive. Did I miss it? Was that even a human?"

The more he walked, the less he thought of the monster, and his thoughts shifted back to his wife. This was the longest he had ever left her unsupervised; surely her caretaker had left to spend time with her family. Geo missed his sweet, caring wife and longed to hear her call him by that nickname she gave him. So all he could do was think about the past.

Ten years ago, along the coastal shores of Canada, George spent his summer vacation studying alone. His friends invited him to study with them, but he seemed to be the only one actually working. His friends were all playing while he was struggling to read. The noise was unbearable, and although he was under the beach cabanas, the bright sun made it even more difficult for his weak eyes to read, so he held the book closer.

"Nerd."

He ignored the voice and continued to read with his book three inches away from his face, but the voice persisted.

"Hiding won't make me go away. Are you scared of pretty ladies, or do you hide from everyone?"

"I can't see well."

"Is that why you always sit in front? Maybe you should buy glasses like normal people."

George lowered his book. "Maybe if I was 12 like you, I could have asked mommy or daddy to buy some for me, but glasses are expensive."

"I am 16, asshole."

"What's the difference, pretty lady? You're a child."

"At least I have friends."

"I have friends."

George stood up to prove his point, looking for the friend who had invited him, only to realize they had left and forgotten about him. Once he noticed, he sat back down, flustered. The girl began to laugh.

“I'm Jameria. What about you?”

“George.”

“Can I call you Geo? I'm not good at remembering names.”

“No, you can’t. I'd rather you not call me anything. In fact, I would be happy if we never talked again.”

“Asshole. This is why you have no friends.”

“Where are your friends?”

“How about you become my first friend?”

Summer vacation flew by quickly, and Jameria kept calling George, though he tried to ignore her. Soon, the new semester started.

“Geo, hey!”
“How did you get my landline? And when did you get into the same college as me?”
“I attended the University of Toronto before you. This is my last semester.”
“How did a 12-year-old get into college?”
“Asshole, we are around the same age! Why do you always act like you're older?”
“I’m 20. People will start making up rumors if you keep following me around campus.”
“What rumors? No one pays attention to you anyway. Look at this.”
She handed him a Polaroid photo of a group of teens at the beach.
“You have friends?”
“You're the only one who doesn't, Geo. We went to high school together; I was trying to invite you, but…”
“But I don't have the time.”
“I get that, but friends are important too.”
George's frustration with Jameria grew, and their one-sided friendship continued. Jameria would follow him everywhere, and others started using his new nickname.
The semester was long and difficult. George didn't look forward to his results, but there was a sunny beam of light seemed to follow him, and his face wore an uncharacteristic smile. As he walked to the notice boards, his unfamiliar smile, juxtaposed with his usual awful mood, made him look like a creep to the classmates who noticed. Jameria passed George without saying a word; when with friends, her words were short, which made George curious, but regardless, he was happy to be away from her. Students surrounded the notice board, looking for their grades, while some were only there to compare results. Jameria held her friend's hand and navigated through the crowd while George stood at the back, waiting for the crowd to pass.
Jameria knew that this was the last time she would see George, so she waited. She wanted to know if Geo would say anything to her or if he even remembered. Unfortunately, she was unprepared for the truth; as she left the notice board with her friend, talking about what they would do after school, her eyes glanced at Geo. They never spoke that day, nor any day after.
As the crowd died down, he checked his GPA. It was 4.49 a mark away from perfect, but he had gotten used to it. He quickly scanned the notice board to see who did better; one student had a GPA of 1.2, and the average was 2.9, but the only one who got higher was Jameria.
“George? How are you hanging in there?” a familiar voice asked.
George looked up. It was his one friend or the closest thing he had to one Damian, a giant. He had stood at six feet at the age of 15, and as they grew up, Damian continued to grow until he was now seven feet tall. His height made it easy to get attention from women, contrasting with George, who was very short.

“I'm well. Did you check your GPA?”
“Nah, is it even that important? You need to loosen up, man.”
“It is.”
“Whatever, man. Me and a couple of guys are going to have a frat party. Wanna come?”
“I wouldn't be able to come.”
“There will be loads of women with massive... well, personalities and GPAs."
“I'm sorry, but I've got to study before the next semester.”
“Do you like the ones with smaller personalities? You seem like you're more into that anyway.”
“What do you mean?”
“That girl you were always with. How do you know her anyway?”
“Last semester the beach you left me at, Damian.”
“Sorry, man, but it was the only way to get you out of the books.”
“Maybe you wouldn't have gotten a 1.2 if you studied.”
“That high? I'm always improving!"
“1.2 isn't good.”
“Whatever, man.”
Damian could tell that something had changed George, and he thought to himself, "Was it that girl? Regardless, I hate that pretentious twat. I'm his only friend, yet he keeps lecturing me."
The rest of Geo's school life had become uneventful, but he had started to miss Jameria's pestering. He strived to do better than her in the future, even though, though only 16, she was ahead of her class and the valedictorian of that year's graduating class. Each year that passed, Geo's opinion of her changed; initially, he thought she was just a rich "airhead" thrust into college by her parents, but she was hard-working and still made time to develop her personal life, unlike George.
As George navigated his school life, he focused not only on studying but also on his social life. His cold exterior eroded, and he became a friendlier person. His peers realized this change and he gained friends, but Damian slowly distanced himself from him. Jameria had become George's hero; if it wasn't for her, he wouldn't have understood the importance of having friends.
George's final semester was ending, and grades were posted to the notice board. He managed to raise his GPA to 4.5, but more importantly, he had friends. Geo didn't care to check the notice board right away, so he slept in the college's dorms a bit longer while his classmates all rushed to see who would be graduating. George couldn't sleep; it was 8:00 AM, and he wasn't used to sleeping past seven, so he thought about his life and the friends he had made because of that girl.
Eventually, he got excited to see what his hard work had allowed him to accomplish. At the notice board, kids were packed together as usual, but they made way for George, pointing and whispering. Surely my grades can't be that good, right? Jameria was far more popular, and she got the same grade. Maybe I did poorly?

“Creep!” one shouted.
“How didn't I know what he was?”
“Well, he always looked at me weirdly."
“RAPIST!”
At the top of the notice board, the word "RAPIST" was spelled out using a blood-red marker. Underneath it was a picture of George at the beach with Jameria, pictures of women's undergarments, a photo of Jameria and her friends in bikinis, and various vulgar notes all connected with pins and red yarn. One note claimed that George had assaulted and then blackmailed a 16-year-old to be his friend. Another claimed that he had sneaked into the women's washroom and stolen undergarments. One yarn led to another notice board with Jameria’s photo and a number of women's garments in his dorm; the notice board had been transformed into an evidence board of false accusations. He reached out to remove the slander, but another student slapped his hand away. They all stood between him and the board; to them, this was justice.
“We aren't leaving until a lecturer sees this and the school launches an investigation.”
“Where are the lecturers?”
George ran back to the dorms, where he bumped into a familiar tall figure.
“Damian!”
“Don’t talk to me.”
“Did you see the notice board?”
"Didn't I say don't talk to me?”
“You know I didn't do any of that, don't you?”
“I know.”
“Then why?”
“I don't care if you did, bro. Just don't talk to me, ok?”
One thought raced through his mind: What if it was all Damian? But why? He immediately pushed the thought out of his mind; after all, Damian was a true friend. Similarly to Jameria, he had always tried to pull Geo out of his shell and into civil society. When he returned to his dorm, he lay awake, unable to get over the ordeal. He never got to see his grades, nor did he get any rest.
The next day, he had almost forgotten about the incident after all, he was used to being alone but the cold, indifferent eyes his classmates once had were incomparable to the pure disdain they now carried. He tried going to the school's main office, but the students' eyes felt like arrows raining down to pierce their enemy. He was defenseless and alone, so he delayed it and went to the notice board to see his grades.

There was a petition to get him suspended, pinned with over 50 signatures. He had gained the highest achievable score, but what was the point? He had nobody to celebrate with, and nobody cared for him. Next to the notice board was the office. During the school year, it was lively, but as the semester came to a close, it had died down.

He knocked on the door, and no one answered.

“Hello?”

“Come in.”

“Is the school aware of what happened yesterday?”

“Yes, we have contacted the police, but we can’t suspend or arrest anyone without solid proof. If you would like to make a report, please fill out this form. We are investigating alongside the police.”

Geo left without saying another word. The school has labeled me a rapist, he thought. He returned to his room and started packing.

Will I graduate?

Then suddenly, there was a knock at the door. It was Jameria; she had matured.

She explained that the school had called, prying for information on him.

“It's weird, right? I tried asking them why, but they kept asking me stupid questions. What's up?”

Geo said nothing at first, but Jameria's persuasiveness and people skills had grown. She began to walk him through her life moving from an accountant to a fashion designer to a model. She had built her own successful business selling clothes and talked about how she had traveled across the world.

“Argentina is nice, and I was actually thinking…”

“Why?”

“Why what?”

“Why do you keep talking?”

“If you told me what happened, I'd leave.”

He explained what happened. She apologized for everything and blamed herself.

“I know you hated me, but you're not going to have to see me again because I'm moving to Argentina.”

“I don't hate you.”

“If you're ever looking for a job after school, call.”

She gave him a business card and walked away. The moment she left, he threw it away. The school investigation eventually revealed that George was innocent and forbade students from using the notice board for anything other than club activities. Geo achieved the highest GPA amongst the students, but because of the incident, the school decided it would be best to declare another student as the valedictorian.

The newspapers covered the story, and the school's silence on the matter caused even George's parents to limit their communications with him. In the end, George graduated not as the valedictorian he desired to be, but as a rapist in the eyes of his peers.

After college, George hopped from job to job, but the title of a rapist followed him everywhere. He moved to Argentina in 1994 to escape this life, but the job-hopping persisted. A year later, he settled into a permanent job where he met a familiar face: Jameria was the accountant of the company he worked for. She explained that at 21, it was hard to work for her former modeling agency and that her business had failed. They reconnected, and Geo explained that the school had died without her lively energy when she left, admitting he had started to miss her. George began to look at her less like a child and more the way a man looks at a woman. His work was very lucrative, and he could even afford to buy a Bentley Continental T.

Jameria confessed that she had always looked up to Geo's determination, and the two would later marry. Regardless of how often they tried, they were unable to bear children, so they adopted a 10-year-old boy named Ray. Geo became a police officer, and Jameria stayed home to look after their adopted son.

"Hey, Jameria, I am home."

"I can make you dinner if you're hungry."

"No, I can make dinner myself. Where is Ray?"

"He's still at school, dear."

"I hope he's making friends."

"He takes after me more, so he should be fine."

"I do hope so."

Ever since Ray had left the orphanage, he had lost his childlike innocence and the bright smile that used to light up a room. He had been the oldest at the orphanage, and after watching his friends all leave, he had learned how to behave around adults if he wanted to get adopted. Ray wasn't their biological child, but to Jameria, there was no difference; she was patient with him and taught him how to be a kid. He was cold and distant, only calling his adoptive parents by their names, but slowly he started to call Jameria "Mother."

The cathode-ray tube television made it difficult for anyone to hear the landline, but the ringing continued. After Geo was done making dinner for himself, he left the kitchen and answered the phone.

"Can you turn the TV down? I can't hear the phone."
“Sorry!”
“Hello?”
“Jameria?”
“It's for you, dear,” he said while clamping his hand over the bottom of the phone.
“What?” she replied while twisting the television volume knob up.
“Turn the TV down!”
She lowered the knob to say, “Look at the time. Ray must be done with school.”
Jameria left to get Ray, and Geo got stuck in an awkward conversation. Jameria’s mother insisted that she had been calling all day and that he must have done something to the landline to steal her daughter away. Their relationship was strained; she blamed George for the failure of her daughter's business and formerly successful life. She pressed George for details on his job and what car he was driving, and demanded to see Ray. Geo only answered using "Yes, ma'am" he was afraid of the harsh personality built by years of strict teaching. She hung up after berating him, and a little while later, Jameria returned.
“Why didn't you tell me?”
“Shh, not in front of the kid, dear.”
“You dumped her onto me, though.”
“How would I know it was my mother?”
“She said she was calling all day. I should have known, when do you even watch television? You owe me, okay?”
“Okie dokie.”
Ray, usually quiet, said, “Mom, I'm hungry.”
“How about you let Dad make his famous...”
“Mister George isn't good at cooking.”
“Haha! True, Mister George isn't good at many things. I'll make dinner.”
Jameria went to the kitchen. Under the microwave stand was a spot that she swore wasn't there when she last used the kitchen. The white marble countertop looked yellow beneath the incandescent bulbs. Every item seemed to have been moved, placed where they shouldn't be: the black pepper was in the fridge, and the ketchup sat too close to the mustard. She strapped her cleaning apron around her waist and used spandex gloves along with a cleaning brush to decontaminate her kitchen. After cleaning, Jameria prepared a list of items they would need and prepared to leave, but her husband stopped her before she could go.

“Done so fast?”
“No, you used up all my ingredients.”
“You could have asked me for what you needed”
“No, but you owe me, okay?”
“Sure, sure, whatever.”
George kissed Jameria's forehead as she left, with the TV still playing in the background.
“Dad, when will Mom be back?”
“She should be back soon.”
He finally called me father, George thought, feeling happy. If only that could last for a while longer.
Hours passed, and Jameria wasn't home. George sent Ray to bed, though he was worried. What could he do? At 12:00 AM, the landline rang.
“Who could be calling this late?”
It was the police precinct of Puerto Madero.
“George, come to the station now.”
“This late?”
“It's your wife.”
George crept through the house quickly, grabbed his keys, and bolted to the station in his Bentley Continental T. He blew through every stoplight, focused only on getting to the station. When he arrived, they led him to the investigation room. Looking through the two-way mirror, he saw a woman wearing only a coat and handcuffed to a chair. A biker's helmet sat on her head, and the room was childproofed.
“What is this?”
“I am as clueless as you, George. All she said was that her head hurt after smashing it into the table. She hasn't said anything since. Mr. A—”
“Who is this?”
“It's your wife.”
George burst through the door and demanded the detective leave, then removed the helmet from her. The helmet fell to the ground; her face was covered in blood, and her left eyelid was swollen purple. Countless scenarios played in his mind. Did my coworkers do this just because of bad driving? He should have let her go. He blamed himself, but he couldn't get over her blank eyes. He tried talking to her, but she didn't respond. He took off the handcuffs, and before he could sit on the opposite side, she lunged at him. She overpowered him and dug her nails into his right eye. The investigators rushed in to restrain her and explained what had happened.

“An hour ago, a man called and said he was being chased by a ghost. Of course, we assumed it was a prank call.”
“Get to the point.”
“Your wife attacked a family, injuring the mother and daughter. We aren't sure what they did or why she was naked, but the family says she came out of nowhere. Thankfully they are alive hopefully, they don’t press charges.”
George, clenching his right eye, looked over at his wife's blank expression.
“What happened?” The wind carried his voice, but nothing was returned.
What followed was a weary battle in court. George hired the best lawyer and poured all his resources into resolving the issue quickly before the media got involved, knowing how brutal investigative journalism could be. He sold his car and his house, and used every dollar he and his wife had saved to send Ray to college. The court settled on 115,000 pesos, or Jameria would be sent to a psychiatric hospital. He borrowed money from the bank to pay it off, but his wife never returned to her cheerful self again.
When his wife came home, the first thing she did was lunge toward Ray. He extended his arms to embrace his mother, but how could he have known she was trying to attack? The incident left a permanent scar on the boy's already troubled heart. Maybe it was a lack of proper diet, but George was able to restrain her. The next day, he began to pack Ray's belongings.
“Why didn't Mom wake me up for school?”
“You're going away for a while.”
“Do y'all hate me?”
“No! But you can't live with Mommy or Daddy anymore.”
“Are you sending me back to the orphanage?”
“No, you're going to live with your grandmother.”
“But I don't like her, and she doesn't like me.”
“Your grandmother loves you, Ray.”
“Was it something I did?”
George hugged the boy and explained that he had to be strong from now on. He told him that he wasn't sure if he would ever be able to come home, insisting that it was all his fault and that neither his mother nor Ray had done anything wrong. When Jameria’s mother arrived, she said nothing; she had already poured her heart out over the phone. She hated George for ruining her daughter's successful life, but now she despised him for making her "disabled”.“She must have gone crazy serving your lazy ass all the time,” she had said before hanging up. George spent weeks looking for ways to cure his wife. He swapped the direction of a spare bedroom handle and locked her in for her safety. She would scratch and bang her head against the walls; even though the walls were padded and the floor was made of chestnut wood, the noise echoed through the dead house.

One of the detectives recommended a therapist named Agustín, though counseling centers were halfway across the country. George would have to wait for his annual visit to Puerto Madero or pay for him to come out. Unable to find a closer therapist or wait any longer, he borrowed more money. When the therapist arrived, he was appalled by the state of Jameria's living quarters. The wall padding was punctured, and the floorboards were raised in every direction like a broken Piano. Jameria's straitjacket barely contained her fidgeting, and she wore an animal cone. "Fitting," he thought, standing on all four limbs as she was indistinguishable from a feral animal.

George explained what had happened to her, and the therapist tried talking to her. Afterward, he claimed he was unable to do anything, though he assumed there was severe damage to her brain and recommended a neurosurgeon named Mateo. He also suggested heavy doses of olanzapine and risperidone, diagnosing Jameria with Anorexia Nervosa, Cyclothymic Disorder, Depersonalization-Derealization Disorder, Disruptive Mood Dysregulation Disorder, Exhibitionistic Disorder, Generalized Anxiety Disorder, Insomnia Disorder, Intermittent Explosive Disorder, Narcolepsy, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder, and Trichotillomania.

George went to Dr. Mateo's office, which luckily was close. He explained what had happened, then carried Jameria into the testing room.

"I've seen tumor resections, shrapnel, and machete wounds, but this? I'm not sure what you and your wife are into, but it looks like someone licked the temporal lobe."

"What do you mean?"

"Honestly, I'm not sure if it would do anything to her, but it looks like someone stuck their tongue up her ear. There is no physical damage done to her brain, though."

"Why do you say that?"

"Looking at these chemical markers. There isn't any structural damage whatsoever, but to put it bluntly: I found saliva in her brain."

"We've already sent a sample down to pathology for an enzyme analysis. With the moisture on her brain, we should be able to track whose saliva it is. That being said, this has nothing to do with her deteriorated state. I think it's probably a bit simpler. Go to any clinic and have them examine her body."

"What happened to her?"

"She was assaulted. This isn't the second time I've had a person lose their mind after being raped."

The medication helped to calm Jameria, but she couldn't eat by herself or even walk, her eyes lifeless as if she had regressed to an infant. Geo loved his wife regardless. Ray never visited, but while he was at work, George hired a caretaker for her. If he ever missed a dose of her medication, she would go into a manic rage, and she never slept through the night. Every night, he cried and prayed, "Please wake up," but she never did.

The rowdy shouts of “¡Feliz Año!” and the chaotic clinking of champagne glasses from the loudest neighbors on the block tore him away from the past. He was just four blocks away now, so he picked up the pace. His house stood desolate on a dead-end hill; the lights were off, and the gloomy atmosphere strongly contrasted with his neighbors.

Knock, knock...

“I’m home,” he said, knowing no one would answer back, but it was just a habit. He wrapped his hand around the handle, and the door slowly cracked to the world.

“That's odd, but who would want anything from my rundown shack?”

“It must have been that caretaker. Caretaker? Money-taker is more like it.”

Geo looked around to find the power switch, but even after flipping it, the pitch-black darkness didn't lift. He tried to navigate carefully around the house, but bumped into everything. The soft couch felt a bit lower; he even tipped a vase over.

“Hopefully, she's still asleep.”

He made it past the living room and managed to find the breaker box in the hallway. He flipped one switch, and the fridge started humming in the kitchen. Another switch turned on the fans, but he regretted touching the last one: the room lit up, and as Geo's eye adjusted to the light he fell to his knees.

An electrical cord tied the body of the caretaker to an outlet. She was bruised and burned, the wire seemingly intertwined into her flesh. She lay in a massive pool of blood, but it was not her own. George's bloody footprints were scattered across the ground.

Above the caretaker hung the body of Geo's wife, lifeless body dangled from the ceiling, tied securely with polypropylene rope. A knife was plunged into her throat, and the blood had turned her white dress red. George walked to his wife, her red eyes staring into his soul.

“Maybe she's just sleeping,” he muttered.

He slowly untied her, then pulled the knife from her neck. He gently shook her body in the half-dry blood.

“Wake up, dear.”

He shook her violently and cried, "Please wake up," but she never did.

CHAPTER 3

The Skeleton in my backyard

George Gagnon sat hunched over at his office desk in the police precinct of Puerto Madero. He seemed unbothered by his wife's death that morning. On his computer, he was browsing the police database for the report he had made early that day about the assault of two nameless victims, one male and one female. His report stated that he had seen a woman running naked along the esplanade. He had stopped and questioned her, and she told him she was almost raped but a stranger had saved her. She pointed to the bridge, and he followed. There he saw the naked body of a young man lying unconscious, and above him a bald, tall figure. He chased after the man, but he got away. When Geo returned to the bridge, the two victims had left. He wanted to know who would be working on the case, but he found nothing, not even his report.

"Geo, you're gonna ruin your only good eye staring at that computer all day."

"I'm working, unlike you."

"Back in my day, officers worked in the field."

"Is Mr. Sergio in his office?"

"Yes, but he's a very busy man."

Geo tiredly pushed himself off the old office chair and left the room for the elevator. He punched in five hundred and fifty-six, a secret code he had figured out. Punching fifty-five in front of any number guaranteed a faster arrival, because it tricked the elevator into skipping two levels. He wasn't sure how it worked, but after his wife had childishly spammed the buttons, it only stopped at level four and skipped two and three. At the highest level, six, were the highest-ranked officers. Others went to that floor only to file papers, but Geo strode in as though he owned it. He walked into Mr. Sergio's office, his freshly shaved head making him look more terrifying.

"Mr. Sergio, have you reviewed my report?"

"Which one?"

“Incident 102-B: the assault of a male—”

“You do know I don’t have the time to look over every report you make, right?”

“Yes, but it’s very important.”

“Then I would assign our top officers to work on it.”

“Who would be working on the case?”

“Your hands are full. Focus on your own case.”

“Why can’t I find any information?”

“The system is fairly new. You’re probably the only one who uses it. Everyone else likes physical paper. You just made the report, and the IT team will upload it to the system soon.”

Geo knew that the IT team worked around the clock to ensure that all paperwork was uploaded to the system. It seemed as though someone was purposely hiding his report. He waited at his office desk to see if the report would be uploaded. After some hours, he left for his lunch break. On his way out, at the report office, he saw the same boy from his report. Other officers were whispering.

“Maybe he just made it up. A stranger robbed him of everything, clothes and all?”

“In the safest city in Argentina, unarmed? Sounds like bullshit to me.”

“Insurance fraud, maybe?”

Geo walked over to Riderz, who sat grinding his teeth.

“Robbery? Come with me.”

“What do you want?”

Riderz followed Geo through the precinct's main parking lot. At the back was an old 1991 Yugo GV Plus. It appeared to have once been painted red, but rust had overrun the paint, leaving only bits of red visible. The only thing that kept the car afloat was its rims, with the flattened tires acting only as support. Geo pulled the door handle three times before it opened. The door was barely supported by its hinges, swinging as clumsily as a drunk driver navigating a highway. After sitting in the front, he demanded that Riderz accompany him.

"What's your name, kid?"

"Where are we going?"

"We need to talk."

"About what?"

"I saw what happened."

"What are you talking about?"

"The rapist."

Riderz's face stiffened with dread. He didn't want to be known as a rape victim, but Geo assured him that he wouldn't let anyone know. He explained that the police wouldn't care enough to work on the case, so it would be up to them. Geo questioned Riderz about the appearance of the shadowy figure. Riderz claimed he had been under the influence, but he described the man's skin as dark as the night sky during an eclipse. His skin seemed to absorb light, and his lips were big and blood red. If light consumed darkness, he consumed the light. Every feature on his face was misplaced, as though painted by a toddler. Geo assumed the description falsely exaggerated the features of the rapist, but with such an odd figure, how could he be certain?

"Riderz."

"What?"

"My name is Riderz."

“How did you get such a stupid name?”

“Where are we going?”

Geo said nothing and continued driving. The asphalt beneath the car was a mosaic of worn patches, and loose gravel pitched against the undercarriage while the muffler banged at every pothole. A musty aroma almost hid the exhaust fumes and the sweetness lingering in the air. As they drove, each house grew more decrepit. The fences were mismatched pieces of old wooden pallets, painted over so many times that the layers cracked like tree bark. Electrical wires crisscrossed overhead as though woven by a psychotic spider, with plastic bags and abandoned shoes swinging in the breeze like laundry. They drove past a rowdy family, shouting and screaming, while children ran around the yard savagely banging sticks on each other’s heads. They stopped at a dead end on a hillside, where a punctured bicycle lay beside a battered, desolate wooden shack. Geo led Riderz into the backyard, where he assumed they would be looking to arrest the shadowy rapist. Instead, there was a seven-foot-deep hole with a makeshift ladder hanging in it. Geo handed him a shovel and demanded that he dig.

Riderz nervously joked, “Is the hole for me?”

“No, but I need your help digging.”

“I have to get back to work.”

“I need your help digging, and I have to get back to work as well to update my report.”

Riderz understood clearly: he was being blackmailed. If he didn’t help this stranger, everyone at work would know he had been assaulted. The woman he liked, and more importantly Randy, the guy who stole her from him, would all think less of him. Whatever the man was plotting, Riderz was now a part of it. They dug for hours, carrying buckets of mud up the makeshift rope ladder until the sun slept. Geo crawled out and told Riderz he could go home, but he stayed to see what he had become involved in. Geo went into the house and dragged out a heavy-duty polyethylene drum, each loose floorboard slowing the tedious progress of moving three hundred pounds. Riderz thought about offering a hand, but the situation was odd, and he was already involved enough. Geo unlatched the closure ring seal and uncovered the drum. A sharp, heavy acidity replaced the air, and it smelled metallic. The odor burned Riderz’s eyelids, and his lungs felt as though they were on fire.

The scent made his stomach bring up what he had eaten earlier. Geo poured a red, gelatinous sludge into the hole, and Riderz asked, curious,

“What are you doing?”

“I was going to cover the hole, but since you’re still here, grab a shovel.”

When the hole was covered, Geo returned to the shack and Riderz followed. Half of the house was made of bricks and the rest of wood, and Christmas decorations hung everywhere. They walked through the main hallway. One room had an inverted handle with latches on the outside, which made Riderz worry about the officer’s character. Maybe he was the rapist’s associate. At the end of the hallway, to the left of the doorway, was an old four-burner stove and a mini fridge. To the right was a crooked table with four chairs. Geo started cooking and told Riderz to wash up in a back room. After cleaning the dirt from his hands, Riderz returned to the kitchen, where Geo ate alone at the crooked table.

“Go home, kid.”

“I wouldn’t mind staying for dinner.”

Riderz needed to know what the sludge was, so he tried to insert himself into the stranger’s solitary dinner, even though the food smelled awful. Before he could continue his interrogation, there was a bang at the door. It was Geo’s mother-in-law, who came every year to check on her daughter’s mental state. Geo paid no mind to the sudden banging. In the heavy silence, Riderz couldn’t help but wonder who had slammed against the door with enough fury to nearly rip it off its rusted hinges.

“George, I know you’re inside. I can see your car.”

“Maybe we should open the door,” Riderz whispered.

Geo opened the door, and his mother-in-law’s massive frame barely squeezed through the wooden doorframe. She complained about every detail of the house that seemed to have worsened. She sat at the crooked dining table, and its chair could barely contain her. Maggie asked if he had prepared anything for her to eat. He set two other plates beside his own, and Riderz assumed he was being

invited to dinner, so he sat, even though he wanted no part of Geo's shady business. Every year, Maggie would ask to see Geo's kid, but he always came prepared with an excuse for his absence.

"You said you would bring Ray. Where is he?"

"He's studying. If only you were diligent like him, my baby would still be here. Messing around with my sixteen-year-old when you should have been studying. It's all your fault she's like this. Where is she? Has she been eating well, or have you been starving her?"

"She's eating well, I hope."

"What do you mean you hope?"

"She's not here."

"Where is she?"

"A psychiatric hospital."

Maggie threw the plate of hot food into Geo's face. She flew into a manic rage, screaming that he had destroyed her daughter and then disposed of her. She said that as long as she lived, Geo would never see his daughter, and he would never see his nephew again. Riderz did not attempt to defuse the situation, and no one could utter a word through Maggie's tantrum. She left in a rage, banging the door behind her so hard it came off its hinges. Riderz didn't try to console Geo, but he wanted a ride home.

"I can't walk back home. Can you give me a ride?"

Riderz continued to ask, but Geo ignored him and kept eating, even though his forehead was bleeding and he was covered in food. Eventually, Riderz left, walking down the hill and past the broken neighborhood. The strange ordeal had almost made him forget what had happened to him that morning. When he arrived home, his dog, Sparky, greeted him, his tail wagging constantly and hitting his foot. Even though Riderz had a family, they had never been a part of his life. He recalled his parents' cold eyes from childhood, but that was the limit of the portraits in his memory. His parents' riches had afforded him a caretaker, but he had never experienced the loving warmth of his parents.

Riderz didn't shower or change into comfortable clothes. He lay on his bed, watching 12 Monkeys, and fell into a deep sleep. Maybe it was his constant television watching, but his dreams were always weird. He dreamt that he was living underground with the last survivors of humanity. They all wore cloaks with long sleeves that draped to the ground, and they survived on crops. No one dared to venture into the overworld, but the cramped space made him nauseous, so he eventually sneaked to the surface, knowing he would never be able to return. In this dystopian dream, the surface was sometimes a cold tundra and sometimes desolate sandlands, and he was always alone.

On the surface there were no crops, so he feasted on fresh raw meat. Riderz began to feel like a king. Underground, food was rationed unfairly and women were only allowed to speak to selected males, but on the surface he was free to take anything he found. There was no animal stronger than him until he ran into one: a tall, dark figure without any physical body. Every attack he threw at it passed through it, but it was free to do whatever it wanted to him. The monster lunged at him, pinned him to the floor, and drove a long metal rod into him. He jolted up from the dream, clamping his backside where the rod had been inserted. In a cold sweat, he repeated to himself, "It was just a dream." After the dream, he was unable to sleep. It seemed to have reopened his old wounds. He had been raped, and that wasn't a dream. Riderz stayed up that night watching television.

Hours passed, and he was still trying to drown his thoughts with television, but nothing seemed to calm his mind. He started to feel as though he was missing something, so he roamed his house looking for what he needed. "Maybe I left the stove on? No." When he reached his closet, he realized what it was. He should have been at work. He had already missed one day, and if he lost his job, his parents would stop sending him a monthly allowance. So he dragged himself to work.

Riderz dragged himself through the casino's doors. The ringing slot machines and the heavy, fluorescent hum of the casino floor felt as though they were pounding against his brain. He removed his coat, which ruffled his thick, dark jacket. The jacket clashed with his red-and-white-striped tie, and anyone who looked at him could tell he had pulled anything out of the closet. He barely had time to fix his jacket before his manager intercepted him, face red with frustration.

"You're late, Riderz, and missing your shift on Tuesday set everyone back," his boss snapped, throwing a clipboard onto the counter.

“I had stuff come up,” Riderz muttered.

“Well, since you have more important things to do, maybe you don’t need a job.”

“It was a medical emergency, sorry.”

“You owe us hours. Since you’re sorry, you’ll be taking over the double shift at the main tables tonight.”

Riderz swallowed his pride and nodded. He didn’t need to work, but his parents wanted to think they had raised a functional adult. He walked over to the breakroom counter, where he saw Klair looking through the duty logs. She handed him a stack of task sheets with a quick, preoccupied smile.

“I’m very sorry, Riderz, but can you help a girl out?” she said, handing him the paperwork. “You’ll need to cover these tables too. It was supposed to be my shift, but you wouldn’t mind helping out a friend.”

Her words cut his already broken heart. He thought he was over her after New Year’s, but he couldn’t get over her. At first, Riderz had thought Klair was a kind-hearted girl who liked him, but she acted the same way toward all her male coworkers. Ever since Riderz had confessed his feelings to her on New Year’s, he had started to see the truth. She said they should remain friends, but she just wanted him to do half her work. He kept his head down, reading Randy’s name at the top of the sheet. Riderz felt a heavy weight on his chest. Randy was a new employee, a young Black man hired only a few weeks ago, but his confidence and quick charm had gotten him promoted above Riderz. Riderz had always harbored racial prejudices, but Randy inflamed those prejudices into active malice.

Riderz sneaked off to the breakroom and tried to replicate Randy’s dialect in the mirror, picturing himself talking with Klair. He leaned closer to the glass, trying to mimic the smooth confidence of Randy’s voice. Riderz cleared his throat and tried out a line.

“Hey, Klair, you’re looking good tonight, baby,” Riderz muttered to the mirror, trying to force an easy, relaxed posture. “How about you and me…”

“You gotta put a little more soul into that, man,” a voice chuckled from behind him.

Riderz froze. In the mirror's reflection, Randy was leaning on the doorframe with an amused grin on his face. Riderz's face glowed red with embarrassment as he spun around to reply.

"I was just trying... I wasn't doing anything, really."

"No judgment here, brother. I get it. You're trying to ask out Klair, right? We've all been there."

He pulled out a chair and sat down, looking at Riderz with what seemed like friendly advice.

"Listen, women like confidence. Ditch the script. You gotta loosen up, man, drop your shoulders, act natural, actually listen to what she's..."

To anyone else, Randy seemed like a cool coworker offering a helpful tip to someone who clearly struggled with women. But beneath Riderz's quiet compliance, the advice only made the resentment burn hotter. Randy's words blurred, and Riderz could only focus on the fact that Randy had seen him. In his mind, he was thinking of keeping Randy silent. Every blurred word out of Randy's mouth felt like an attack. Riderz stared at him, forcing a dull nod while his stomach twisted with bitter hatred. He loathed everything about Randy: his confidence, the way he occupied every room he was in, the way he effortlessly charmed every woman, and especially his skin. Standing there taking romance advice from the exact man he despised felt like a humiliation ritual, only feeding the dark envy he carried inside.

"I'll keep that in mind." Riderz hid his hatred behind a polite smile and slipped out of the breakroom.

He spent the rest of his grueling shift moving mechanically from table to table, carrying the extra burden of Randy's work while his mind churned with bitter thoughts.

While he worked, seeing Randy interact with Klair only poured fuel on his thoughts. Riderz had built an entire fantasy in which Klair said yes and they fell in love on New Year's Eve. Seeing her laugh at Randy's jokes felt like a betrayal of the script he had written in his head.

When the long night finally ended, Riderz drove home in complete silence. He collapsed onto his bed without bothering to change out of his uniform. He kicked his shoes off and switched on the television for background noise, leaving the BBC News broadcast running at low volume. As the

muted reports of world events flickered across his face, his eyes grew heavy, and he finally drifted off to sleep, consumed by fatigue and resentment.

Riderz woke in bed, lying on his side, paralyzed and cold. He wasn't sure if his mind was playing tricks on him, but he saw a seven-foot dark figure standing behind him. Air couldn't escape his lungs, and his backside burned as though he were being penetrated slowly, for hours. His landline ringing pierced the silence, waking him from his nightmare. He followed the ringing downstairs to his living room, and Geo's familiar voice came from the other end.

"Kid, I have a clue. Same place as last time."

The phone hung up before Riderz could reply. He had four hours left before work, so he thought he should hear the new information. In his new jet-black Audi A6, he drove back to Geo's house. When he arrived, he knocked at the front door, but there was no answer, so he crept to the back door. Pickerelweed had overrun the hole they had covered. "Maybe the red sludge was a new type of fertilizer," Riderz thought.

"Why are you creeping through my backyard, kid? The door was open."

"You didn't answer."

Geo led him to the front, where he attempted to start his car. He checked the battery terminals and the gas, and he even tried to jump-start it, but nothing worked. Riderz suggested they use his car, and Geo reluctantly agreed on the condition that he would drive.

"Where are we going?"

"To an old couple who may have encountered the rapist."

"How did you get my number, though?"

"The police database."

Geo checked the database every day, but he couldn't find his report. However, Riderz's report had been uploaded an hour after it was made. After tinkering in the database, he learned that it had been uploaded, but an admin had purposely removed it. He thought that any report relating to

rape might have been removed, but he found several reports relating to rape. One report stood out to him: a lady whose husband had been assaulted.

They drove for hours, stopping only for gas, so Riderz nervously asked,

“How far are we going? I have to get back to work.”

“It’s pretty far. Maybe you should call in sick.”

Hours passed, and night fell. Every few hours, Riderz asked if they were still there yet. Halfway into the journey, on a two-way highway, Riderz fell asleep and Geo’s head started bobbing. Driving on the highway made Geo recall teaching his wife to drive.

Geo sat in the passenger seat of his Bentley Continental T, instructing his wife, Jameria, on the fundamentals of driving a car. At the time, she was twenty-two years old, but the way she operated the car made him wonder if she was a child. The first time he took her out to drive, she overcorrected, and when she got the hang of starting, she thoughtlessly yanked the steering wheel to the right and dipped the car into the roadside drain. When Geo asked why she would do such a mindless thing, she claimed her preconceived idea of driving was as simple as turning the wheel. She had almost begun to understand how to drive, but she was still nervous on the road. On the day of her practical exam, Geo took her out on a last-minute run. The car was in a parking lot at the Comuna 4 Street Circuit, minutes away from the exam center, where he had intended for them to prepare. Jameria’s hands trembled on the steering wheel. She had created her own business and given a graduation speech at the age of sixteen before hundreds of people, but driving seemed to be the only thing she was bad at. Geo leaned in encouragingly, with a hand on her shoulder.

“Alright, deep breath. Remember to check your parking brake before starting. Don’t let the nerves make you forget the basics.”

“Right, brakes first... then... then what?”

“Have you forgotten how to start the car?”

She started the car nervously and slowly pulled out of the parking lot into the busy streets. Every driver felt to her as though they were targeting her, but she persisted. As her nerves lessened, a loud airhorn echoed down the street, and a massive milk truck came speeding out of a hidden street,

drifting directly into her lane to avoid a pothole. Jameria's hands froze, and her eyes widened in absolute horror. If not for Geo's quick thinking, they might not have lived. He lunged across the center console, gripped the steering wheel, and pulled the car to safety.

"Oh gosh... I completely froze. Sorry, dear."

"Are you alright?"

"I'm fine, but if you hadn't pulled the wheel, we would have collided! I think I should reschedule the test."

"No, that truck was in the wrong. I'm sure you'll do well."

Even though Geo tried to calm her, her nerves got the best of her and bled into the exam. Jameria failed on her first attempt, but eventually she overcame her fear of driving.

A loud horn snapped Geo awake to a massive truck heading toward the car. Somehow he was driving on the opposite side of the two-way highway. His reaction was quick, and he pulled the steering wheel to the right, almost escaping the truck, but it was too late. A massive bang echoed through the streets that day, putting an unfortunate end to their hunt for the rapist.